

Based on the industry best practices outlined in your sources—specifically the **VetSec Resume Workshop** and career guides from **The Interview Guys**, **Rora**, and **Candor**—here is a comprehensive Resume Cheat Sheet.

1. Strategic Fundamentals

- **The 10-Second Rule:** Recruiters spend approximately 10 seconds on a first pass. If information is important, it must be on **Page 1** 1, 2.
- **Length:** Limit the resume to **2 to 3 pages maximum** 3. If you are entry-level or a career changer with little relevant experience, stick to **one page** 4.
- **Relevance:** Focus strictly on the last **7 to 10 years** of experience. Recruiters generally do not care what you did 15+ years ago unless it is directly relevant 4, 5.
- **ATS Compatibility:** Avoid using tables, columns, or graphics (like lines), as these break Applicant Tracking Systems (ATS) parsing 6, 7. Use ATS-proof templates 8.

2. Formatting & Contact Info

- **Photo:** Do **not** include a photo of yourself. Definitely do not use a picture in military uniform 9, 10.
- **Email Address:** Do not use AOL or Yahoo email addresses; this can be an automatic disqualifier. Use Gmail or ProtonMail 11.
- **Location:** Always include your **City and State**. Recruiters need to know if you are local or require relocation 12.
- **Hyperlinks:** Include links to your LinkedIn profile (ensure you have a friendly, non-uniform photo there) and GitHub/Portfolio if applicable 11, 12.

3. The "Targeted" Summary (The Formula)

Do not use generic "Objective" statements. Use a tailored summary at the very top to immediately frame your candidacy 13.

- **The Formula:** "I am a Current Role/Adjective seeking a Target Role."
- **Example:** "I am a seasoned cybersecurity professional with 5 years of experience looking for a job as a Cyber Threat Intel Analyst" 13, 14.
- **Tailoring:** If you are a career changer, state it clearly: "I am a transitioning military veteran with a Secret Clearance seeking a role as a SOC Analyst" 14.

4. Professional Experience & Bullets

- **Remove "Fluff":** Delete subjective phrases like "results-driven," "hard charger," "detail-oriented," or "disciplined." These are viewed as garbage/filler 15, 16.
- **Civilianize Language:** If coming from the military, remove jargon. Change terms like "Mission Critical" or "Operational" to **"Critical Infrastructure"** or **"Enterprise Systems"** 17, 18.
- **Impact over Duty:** Do not just list duties. List **impact** and **metrics** 9.
- **Bad:** "Responsible for updating software."

- **Good:** "Implemented proactive maintenance strategies that reduced downtime in hardware areas by 98%" 18.
- **Present Tense:** If you are currently in the job, use present tense verbs (e.g., "Maintaining," "Managing," "Resolving") 19.

5. Skills & Certifications

- **Placement:** If you are new to the field, put Education and Certifications on **Page 1** 2, 20.
- **Validation:** Do not list "Planned" or "In Progress" certifications. Only list what you have achieved 7, 21.
- **Defensibility:** Do not list every tool you have ever touched. If you list a tool (e.g., PowerShell, Splunk) or protocol (DNS, TCP/IP), be prepared to answer deep technical questions about it during the interview. If you can't explain it, take it off 22.
- **Operating Systems:** Do not list "Windows/Linux/Mac" as skills unless you are an administrator for them; simply "using" them is expected 23.

6. Handling "Unrelated" Experience

- **Part-Time Jobs:** If you are a student or career changer, do not list unrelated part-time jobs (e.g., bartender, GrubHub driver) unless they add specific value. They clutter the resume 24.
- **Military Combat:** Unless applying for a role where it is relevant (e.g., special forces security), avoid listing combat deployments or sniper training. It can be controversial and distract from your technical skills 25, 26.
- **Older Work:** Summarize unrelated or older work (e.g., mechanics, infantry) into a single bullet or short section to save space for relevant skills 27, 28.

7. Leveraging AI for Resumes

You cannot let AI write your entire resume, but you can use it to polish specific sections.

- **Recommended Prompt:** "Rewrite and strengthen these bullets using the style of Deloitte or Accenture proposal language." 29.
- **Civilianizing Prompt:** "Rewrite this to take out military jargon and insert civilian terminology for this job field." 3.

8. The Job Application Strategy

- **Leveling:** Understand the level you are applying for (e.g., Entry vs. Mid-Level vs. Senior). Ensure your years of experience align. For example, "Entry Level" in Red Teaming often requires significant prior IT experience, whereas "Entry Level" in a SOC might be truly junior 30, 31.
- **Referrals:** Network to get referrals rather than just "cold applying." Ask: "Do you have a referral system? Would you be comfortable referring me?" 32.
- **Salary Transparency:** When applying, check if the job is in a "Pay Transparency State" (e.g., CA, CO, NY, WA). Use posted ranges in those states to benchmark your negotiation leverage 33, 34.

9. Red Flags to Avoid

- **Controversial Topics:** Do not include religious or political affiliations unless you are applying to a specific organization where that is relevant (e.g., applying to be a CISO for a church) 25.
- **Typos:** Even one error can be fatal. Double-check headers and dates 35.
- **Tables/Columns:** Do not use them; they confuse ATS software 6.
- **"In Progress" Degrees:** If you are a student, do not list "Student" as professional experience. Keep it in the Education section 36, 37.